

HARVINDER SINGH

CREATURE COMFORTS

KIA IS ALL SET TO LAUNCH WHAT IT CALLS ITS RECREATIONAL VEHICLE, THE CARENS, IN INDIA

BY RAHUL GHOSH

At first look, the Carens does not look as muscular or as aggressive as an SUV. The front end design is very different from the Seltos and the Sonet and comes with a sleek set of lights. Overall, the front end design looks smooth rather than sporty. The Carens also rides on smaller 16-inch wheels, a trait more common to an MPV.

The Carens comes with a smart dash and a multicolour interior design. There's a rich blue shade which is coupled to beige inside the cabin and we love the treatment. The dash houses a 10.25 inch infotainment system which offers 66 connected car features apart from being paired to a good set of Bose speakers. The instrument panel is an LCD cluster which offers a plethora of information. Kia is offering a number of safety features in the Carens which include six airbags as standard.

The Carens is a three-row vehicle. Access to the third row is rather easy thanks to the electric folding feature. Just press a button and one seat tumbles forward to allow access to the third row. We were quite surprised to see that the third row is a rather spacious place. With all three rows in use, the Carens still offers 216 litres of boot space.

Kia is offering the Carens with a choice of three engines. We drove the 1.4-litre turbocharged petrol which can sprint to 100 kmph in 10 seconds and offers a fuel economy of 16.2 kmpl in the manual transmission guise. The 1.4-litre turbo petrol comes with a high level of smoothness. On the go, we did feel a lack of power under the 1,500 rpm mark. Things like a speed-breaker where one would expect the car to go in second cog will require a shift to first in most cases. But what is astonishing is the way the motor transforms beyond the 1,500 rpm mark. There is a dollop of power which comes in and that too in a very linear way which allows for steady acceleration. This means cruising in the Carens is fairly easy. With the turbo spooled, even overtaking is no big deal and can be done without having to downshift.

Engines: 1.4L petrol/ 1.5L diesel
Power: 140 bhp@6,000 rpm/ 115 bhp@4,000 rpm
Price: Rs 10.1-19.5 lakh (ex-showroom)

Moving from the petrol to the 1.5 diesel surely meant that we could hear the motor a little within the cabin. Since it is paired to the 6-speed automatic, the diesel variant offered the luxury of paddle shifters and drive modes. The diesel motor offers an abundance of torque, and that means it can zip. The gear shifts are smooth and the driver can play around with the paddle shifters to make the car move at will. In sport mode, things get to enjoyable levels as the motor holds on to the revs providing more go! With a high fuel economy claim, the Carens diesel then makes a lot of sense even now.

Where the Kia really stands out is in the ride and handling department. The suspension is tuned rather well and as a result the Kia offers good ride quality. The car takes on the rough stuff with ease and very little is sent into the cabin. Even the big speed humps could not throw the Carens off-kilter. The steering too is well tuned and light. With a turning radius of just 5.32 metre, the Carens can deal with tight city spaces with ease. ■